



Press Remarks by Commissioner Lahbib on the Humanitarian Aid Communication

Brussels, 27 May 2026

Qui n'a pas de principes ? Tout le monde a des principes !

Mais ce n'est que lorsqu'ils sont soumis à rude épreuve, que l'on sait s'ils seront plus que des principes... Ce n'est qu'une fois confronté à la dure réalité, celle qui exige le choix du courage et du sacrifice, que l'on sait si nos principes sont plus que des postures.

C'est ce qui nous arrive aujourd'hui, nos principes européens sont mis à l'épreuve.

Chaque jour, des règles que nous pensions établies sont remises en question. Ou simplement mis de côté.

Alors nous nous demandons inévitablement :

Nos principes européens sont-ils solides ? Font-ils partie de ce que nous sommes vraiment ? Ou sont-ils simplement de belles paroles que nous gardons pour les discours et oublions dès qu'ils nous font perdre quelque chose ?

Il y a 75 ans, Robert Schuman a eu une vision. Que des nations qui autrefois utilisaient leur force pour se tirer dessus pouvaient utiliser ces mêmes moyens, pour construire la paix ensemble.

Cette vision est devenue l'Union européenne.

Et cette vision ne s'arrêtait pas à nous-même, à notre continent. Il s'agissait d'une conviction plus profonde : que notre humanité, notre sécurité et notre avenir sont indissociables du reste du monde.

Que ce qui arrive aux gens de l'autre côté des océans compte pour nous. La souffrance ne s'arrête pas aux frontières.

Cette vision, puissante, nous y croyons encore aujourd'hui, elle est encore et toujours au cœur du projet européen. Un projet de solidarité, de prospérité et de paix, dans un monde qui l'est de moins en moins.

Le tableau est sombre : près de 240 millions de personnes ont besoin d'aide humanitaire pour survivre. Si ces gens formaient une nation, ce serait la cinquième plus grande sur Terre.

Ce serait l'entière population de l'Allemagne, de la France, de l'Italie et de la Belgique.

Il y a vingt ans, 30 millions de personnes dépendaient de l'aide humanitaire.

Ainsi, en une génération, ce nombre a été multiplié par huit. Pas doublé. Pas triplé. Octuplé.

Un enfant sur cinq, vit dans une zone de guerre ou en fuit une. Un demi-milliard d'enfants. Toute une génération sous le feu des conflits armés.

Il existe aujourd'hui environ 130 conflits actifs dans le monde. C'est plus du double qu'il y a quinze ans.

Et près de 120 millions de personnes ont été contraintes de quitter leur maison l'année dernière. Du jamais vu depuis la Seconde Guerre mondiale.

Comment décrire ces phénomènes ? Il ne s'agit pas d'une tendance, non, c'est une situation inédite, qui exige une réponse inédite. L'ampleur des besoins humanitaire demande une révolution de notre aide humanitaire.

Cette révolution est au centre de notre appel aujourd'hui. Nous devons faire les choses autrement :

être plus efficace, plus rapide, plus proche de ceux qui sont dans le besoin, être plus inclusif aussi...

Nous nous sommes mis au travail, en tant que premier donateur humanitaire au monde, avec nos partenaires de l'ONU pour réformer le système humanitaire mondial.

Et nous nous savons soutenus par nos citoyens.

Neuf Européens sur dix sont fiers de voir leur Union jouer un rôle majeur dans l'aide humanitaire. Un rappel puissant que la solidarité fait partie intégrante de ce que nous sommes.

Et cette mission s'inscrit dans une autre de nos valeurs : celle du multilatéralisme, que nous défendons toujours, car elle est garante du droit international et nous croyons dans un monde basé sur des règles.

Today I am proud to present this Humanitarian Communication, also on behalf of High Representative Kallas. It is a call to our shared humanity, to our European principles, and to strong, collective action for people in need.

It is built on three priorities: protect, perform, and partner.

First, we must protect humanitarian access. Aid must reach people in desperate need, no obstacles, no exceptions.

That means defending international humanitarian law, no matter where it is under threat. We must use Europe's political weight to open doors when aid is blocked and civilians are trapped. Making sure a truck carrying food gets through a checkpoint, children have a roof over their heads, and a hospital has power to keep the lights on.

We want to strengthen EU humanitarian diplomacy, so we can deliver more results on the ground. It will be at the heart of our foreign policy.

Humanitarian diplomacy is how we turn our values into action and secure access for aid workers, protect civilians, and deliver help to people who need it most. In many crises, it is the only channel still open when political dialogue has broken down.

I saw what is at stake during my visit to the Great Lakes Region, where civilians are trapped between bullets and hunger.

I met directly with presidents or ministers in the DRC, Burundi, and Rwanda, as well as with aid workers, civil society, and refugees. I also met with AFC/M23 rebels. We got results that eased the suffering of women, children, and men who have lost everything.

But we need to do more. Long-term results take time and sustained effort. This work continues.

First, we need to agree on common goals and clearer ways of working together between the Commission, the EEAS, and our EU Special Representatives. We also need to strengthen our Team Europe approach. That means better coordination with Member States, speaking with one voice, and delivering common messages and taking common action in contexts where international humanitarian law is being violated.

It means humanitarians, donors, and diplomats working together, not in parallel, to increase the pressure on those who break the rules. It means funding humanitarian organisations so they can advocate effectively for the respect of international humanitarian law. It also means coordinating our communications to push back against the disinformation that targets aid workers and undermines their work.

Speaking of humanitarian workers, the violence against them has reached unprecedented levels. Last year, over 300 aid workers were killed, nearly 200 injured, and over 100 kidnapped, the vast majority of them local staff.

Humanitarian workers are not targets. They are silent heroes, and they must be protected.

I have met these men and women, most recently with the Lebanese Red Cross in Beirut, working around the clock as bombs fall around them. There, more than 100 healthcare workers have been killed and hundreds more injured.

We will do more to protect them through financial support and capacity building and through security training, especially for local workers. They must have the knowledge and tools to operate safely to

protect themselves and the civilians they serve.

We have already launched the "Protect Aid Workers" program in several countries, and we will expand it into a global programme to improve care and support for the victims and survivors of attacks.

Over the past year and a half, I have visited many refugee camps, where I saw women and children suffering. In every crisis, they are the first victims, paying the highest price.

So we are launching SHIELD, *Sexual and Reproductive Health in Emergencies and Life in Dignity* to improve access to sexual and reproductive healthcare in crises and to strengthen support for survivors of gender-based violence.

Our second priority is making sure the humanitarian system performs under pressure, especially with fewer resources. As needs keep rising, the funding falls further behind. So we need to change the way we work. Every euro must go further and faster.

That is why we are reforming humanitarian supply chains. Logistics account for 60 to 80% of all humanitarian spending. We need to cut waste and save money. Every euro saved on logistics is a euro spent on a loaf of bread or a vaccine for a child.

Right now, most organisations use their own transport, their own warehouses, their own suppliers. That duplication costs lives and money. We will help them procure together, buy locally, pool warehouses, share cargo, share data, pre-position supplies, and use Artificial Intelligence to do it smarter.

I saw this firsthand in Panama, where the EU and UN share warehouses and cut costs. When Hurricane Melissa struck Jamaica, supplies got there fast. That is the model.

We also need to transform how we provide funding. For example, we will also scale up cash assistance. The evidence is clear: with the same funding, cash reaches 30% more people than in-kind aid. It is more efficient, more dignified, and it strengthens local economies. People choose what they need. That is not just smarter aid, it is more respectful aid.

We also need to work more closely with our local partners. We will increase our funding, with a target of 25% localisation by 2027, more than double compared to last year.

This gives our local partners real ownership, strengthening their capacity and bringing humanitarian action closer to communities. Concretely, our international partners will now have to explain in their funding proposals how affected communities and local actors are involved in designing and delivering assistance.

We also need good data. Data we can access fast, we can trust, and we can compare, across countries, across crises, and across organisations. Right now, everyone collects data differently, which creates gaps and duplication. That is why we are pushing for shared data, using every available tool, including AI and satellite technology.

Our third priority is partnerships. There is no humanitarian solution to a humanitarian crisis. Fragility and crises are driven by conflict, climate change, and weak governance.

Over half of the world's refugees come from extremely fragile countries, and up to 70% of asylum seekers in the EU come from fragile situations.

If we want to reduce humanitarian need over time, we cannot only respond. We must better connect humanitarian action with development and with peace, what we call the humanitarian-development-peace nexus. That is why we have developed an integrated EU approach to fragility.

I welcome the commitment of High Representative Kallas, Commissioners Síkela and Šuica, and other colleagues to make this a reality.

I saw what this looks like in practice last year in Cox's Bazar, Bangladesh. Local Bangladeshi women farmers, supported by EU development funding, growing and selling food. That food then goes to assist Rohingya refugees, through our humanitarian partners.

It empowers local communities, creates livelihoods, and reduces the tensions that come with hosting large numbers of refugees. It is far more efficient than flying food in from the other side of the world. Sustainable. Circular. Dignified.

We must also build new alliances with third-country donors, international organisations, financial institutions, the private sector, philanthropies, and local partners on the ground.

Syria shows exactly why this integrated approach and broader partnerships matter. Syria has depended on humanitarian aid for years, but now it needs to function as a country, moving from emergency assistance to recovery and real development.

I have met Syrians in refugee camps who desperately want to go back. But they have no homes to return to. No jobs, no schools, no security. Our task now is to help build the conditions that make return possible.

Partnership is the only way to match the scale and complexity of today's crises.

In a world where more and more leaders ask one ruthless question: "What's in it for me? What is my interest"

In that world, we have to ask: where does Europe stand? We always thought the answer was simple. But today, it is not.

Europe is choosing a path based on fairness, cooperation, and something that should never need defending: human compassion.

Compassion for the most vulnerable, wherever they are. Whatever their race, their religion, or the colour of their skin.

This is not naïve. These are tried and tested principles throughout European history.

It is who we are.

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